Return to Moscow

The shockwaves of the June uprising finally caught up with Erich Honecker in May 1955 when he was ‘retired with honour’ as chairman of the FDJ and packed off to Moscow to begin a one-year study course at the Party college. Despite a faint whiff of disgrace – given Grotewohl’s, Norden’s and Schirdewan’s earlier criticisms – Ulbricht pinned a ‘National Gold Medal for Merit’ on Honecker’s blazer and, for good measure, named a trawler from the Baltic fishing fleet in his honour.1

Ulbricht deemed it essential that his protégé expand his academic knowledge, given that during his decade at the FDJ he had hardly found time for thorough political training, despite the SED demanding leadership cadres be properly schooled.

‘So, for the second time I was taking a protracted study trip to the land of Lenin,’ Honecker mused in his memoirs. He recognised that there were large gaps in his education and later wrote he was glad ‘that my party was now giving me yet another opportunity to broaden my knowledge systematically’. The school pushed a stiff regimen on students, requiring tedious lessons on the history of the Soviet Union and the CPSU, basics of Marxism, dialectic and historical materialism, the history of the international labour movement, economics, and political and economic geography. ‘For us, study meant still more thorough comprehension of the laws of social development and the generalised experiences of socialist construction.’ Honecker also attended lectures at other Soviet academies and was particularly interested in talks on military history and political issues. Like in 1930, he was obliged to take an intensive course in Russian, but was a hopeless linguist and still failed to grasp the language.

His education continued smoothly until a bolt from the blue stunned the communist world on 25 February 1956. That evening, Soviet leader Nikita Khrushchev astounded a closed session of the Twentieth Congress by denouncing Stalin as a vicious, half-mad, power-crazed despot: ‘The cult of